

Question 55 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Evaluate the usefulness of the Kirkpatrick model for judging the effectiveness of an organisational training program.

Introduction

Evaluate = usefulness + limitations + how to use it well + a verdict. The Kirkpatrick model judges training at reaction, learning, behaviour and results. The notes already ask HRD to look beyond affective reactions to learning, behaviour and impact on corporate objectives. So the model fits the syllabus. It is not perfect science.

Detailed points

- 1. Usefulness — completeness compared with smile sheets.** It forces attention to learning, job behaviour and organisational results. That matches professional HRD and prevents the entertainment illusion. This is its greatest use.
- 2. Usefulness — a common language with managers.** Four levels are easy to explain to people who fund training. HRD can say: we will not claim success only on tea and venue. Communication value is real in organisations.
- 3. Usefulness — helps design and diagnosis.** If you plan measures at TNA time, objectives become operational. If reaction is high and behaviour is low, look at transfer climate, not only the trainer. The model locates the break in the chain.
- 4. Limitation — causality at level 4.** Sales, quality and profit have many causes. Training may be only one. Over-claiming ‘this course caused 10% profit’ is unscientific. Usefulness falls if the model is treated as proof rather than as a guide.
- 5. Limitation — cost, time and incomplete use.** Behaviour and results need follow-up months later. Many firms stop at level 1; then the model is unused, which is not the model’s fault, but it limits usefulness in practice.
- 6. Limitation — not every programme needs all four levels equally.** A one-hour policy briefing versus a critical safety skill should not consume the same evaluation energy. Usefulness depends on proportionate use.
- 7. How to use it well.** Plan measures early; collect baseline; combine with transfer design (boss support); do not worship level 1; be modest at level 4; use more depth for costly or high-risk training.
- 8. Verdict.** The Kirkpatrick model is highly useful as a guiding framework for judging organisational training effectiveness, especially compared with judging only participant happiness. It is not a mechanical proof of success. Recommend it with judgement, not as four forms to file and forget.

Conclusion. *Useful for completeness, communication, design and diagnosis; limited on causality, cost and one-size use. Verdict: keep Kirkpatrick as the standard HRD map of effectiveness, apply it proportionately and honestly.*